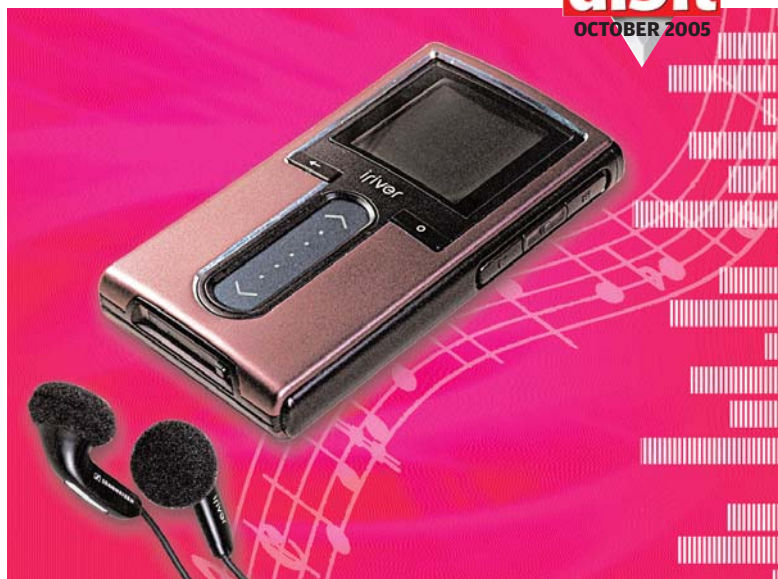




The iRiver H10 has bundled Sennheiser earphones

The Creative Zen Micro was another player that not only looked trendy, but also performed well in our tests. Using a micro drive, even this player delivered good scores in our listening test. The earphones that accompany this player are more like tiny speakers that scream their hearts out at high volume. Voice recording is good, but Line-In encoding would have been a welcome feature.

Its counterpart, the Zen NEEON, was another player that performed very well in our audio quality tests. The Creative ZEN Micro and NEEON followed close behind. The new earphones, which Creative bundles with its ZEN series, are mostly responsible for this.

Software issues apart, the iRiver was one of the best players that we tested. Listening to music on the iRiver was pure pleasure. The voice recording quality and FM reception quality was also good.

The Apple iPods that we received were a generation older, and did hold their own against the competition, but there have been a lot of improved and feature packed players from other companies after them. The iPods, as usual, sailed through the listening tests but did face heavy competition from other players.

The worst of the lot was the NOMAD Jukebox ZEN Extra, which, for all of its bulk, did not even have folder support! Any song that you transferred stayed put in the root of the drive without the folder.

## Data Transfer

The Creative MuVo2 was the fastest in our data transfer tests, clocking 185 seconds. The Apple iPod duo followed close behind while the other players were just average in these tests.

The black sheep in these tests was the Creative NOMAD Jukebox ZEN Extra with excruciatingly slow data transfer speeds.

## Battery Tests

The Samsung lasted a solid 20 hours, which is 5 hours less than its rated battery life, but hey, we are not complaining.

The Apple iPod Mini, followed by the Creative Zen Micro, suffered from low battery life malady with only 7.5 and 8.5 hours of battery life respectively. The other players put in at least over 10 hours in the battery tests with Samsung taking the top honours.

## Conclusion

The HDD-based player comparison saw some stiff competition this year. Not so surprisingly, the iPod duo lost out on features such as FM that came standard on the other players. Of course, the audio quality of the iPods is excellent, but they need to add more features to their players' repertoire.

The Samsung YH-J70 was unanimously adjudged the *Digit* 'Best Buy Gold' winner not only for its sterling performance, but also for the features it bundled. All this at a price that is just a tad more than the iPods!

The iRiver H10 was awarded the *Digit* 'Best Buy Silver' winner for its superb audio performance and also the features that it has. The Creative Zen NEEON did give the iRiver H10 a run for its money in the audio quality department, but sadly lost due to its clumsy interface.

## In The End

The competition just gets better and better each year, with players having more features packed into them.

The Samsung duo border on being called portable digital media players rather than just audio players. Moreover, this is a trend that is fast catching up. Users today have become more demanding and manufacturers are listening to them. With cut-throat competition in the market, there are myriad options available for us users to pick and choose from.

While the capacities on the hard drive-based player keep increasing, this is also a category that sees the most innovations. Motion sensor technology for instance is one of these innovations.

The flash-based players category on the other hand is extremely dynamic with every other manufacturer selling an "MP3 player." For users, this is a boon since they can purchase a no-name portable digital player for rock bottom prices, never mind the quality. The premium manufacturers, however, provide more in terms of features that justifies the price they retail for.

The test this year is just a glimpse of what you can expect in the future. Rest assured, we will be there to help you make the right decision. ☒

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## Contact Sheet

### Portable Digital Audio Players

| Brand     | Company                         | Telephone     | E-mail                             | Web site                |
|-----------|---------------------------------|---------------|------------------------------------|-------------------------|
| Apple     | Apple Computer International    | 1600-425-4683 | indiainfo@asia.apple.com           | www.apple.co.in         |
| Bravish   | Mediaman Infotech Pvt Ltd       | 022-23828100  | sales@mediamangroup.com            | www.bravish.com         |
| Creative  | Creative Technology Ltd         | 98203 57718   | india_getcreative@ctl.creative.com | http://in.creative.com/ |
| Ennyah    | Great World Tech Pvt Ltd        | 022-23892828  | sales@gtechworld.com               | www.ennayah.com.tw/     |
| iRiver    | Salora International            | 011-51614322  | support@iriverindia.com            | www.iriverindia.com     |
| MSI       | Micro-Star International Co Ltd | 011-51758808  | info@msi-india.com                 | www.msi-india.com       |
| Orite     | Mediatech India                 | 022-26361111  | info@mediatechindia.com            | www.orite.com.tw        |
| SAFA      | Arihant Computers               | 022-23822424  | arihant_computers@vsnl.com         | www.safa.co.kr          |
| Samsung   | Samsung India Electronics Ltd   | 011-51511234  | subrotah.b@samsung.com             | www.samsungindia.com    |
| S-Media   | Xserve India (Pvt) Ltd          | 080-5113 1001 | info@xserves.com                   | www.s-media.com         |
| Transcend | Mediaman Infotech               | 022-23828100  | sales@mediamangroup.com            | www.transcendusa.com    |
| Umax      | Neoteric                        | 022-39828600  | sales@neoteric-info.com            | www.umax.com            |
| Yes       | Thakral Computers               | 022-24914090  | prashantgoel88@gmail.com           | www.iloveyes.net        |